

Wired Earphone

Tethered buds for audio lovers

Even though the wireless audio categories have taken over in terms of popularity amongst the general public and launches by audio companies, wired earphones continue to have a certain unparalleled allure amongst audiophiles. Despite advanced Bluetooth technologies now closing the gap between the two, wired earphones still reign supreme for many. Wired earphones from established audio brands are packed to the brim with advanced technology within their diminutive bodies. These include multi-drivers, planar magnets, and other such technologies. Due to the sheer popularity of the wireless audio category, we saw very few launches of wired earphones, especially high-end wired earphones in the Indian market this year. Therefore, this category will only mention the winner and best buy. We only hope that 2022 sees a much higher number of launches in this segment, especially now that wired earphones are sort of coming back in vogue. While the convenience factor of wireless or truly wireless earphones definitely can't be disregarded, there's just something special about good ol' wired earbuds, especially for those who crave balanced and neutral sound. So, let's dive into the winner of the Digit Zero1 Award for the Best Performing Wired Earphone in 2021.



AIWA ESTM-101
Price: ₹1,299

Winner: Sennheiser IE900

Now, these earphones are definitely exorbitantly priced but believe us when we say, they're simply one of the best wired earphones that money can buy. The earbuds feature aluminium housings and come with dynamic TrueResponse transducers at the heart of it all. Additionally, the buds feature a triple-chamber absorber system that stops low-frequency sounds from muddying or veiling high-frequency ones. The Sennheiser IE900 are one of the best-tuned earphones we've had the pleasure of listening to, which is even more impressive when you learn that these are single driver earbuds. The imaging is par excellence and the soundstage is pretty wide as well. The bass response is tight and precise, the mids are clear and aren't masked at all by the bass, and the highs are sparkly and detailed. Honestly, the earphones feel downright surgical in their approach and you will hear details that you simply cannot listen to on consumer-grade earphones. If we had to critique one thing, it would be that the highs are slightly underemphasised in some areas of the treble region and it can cause some minute loss of detail, especially in female vocals. However, this is truly one of the best earphones money can buy, therefore easily winning itself the Digit Zero1 Award in this category.

Best Buy: AIWA ESTM-101

The AIWA ESTM-101 are value-for-money wired earphones that produce a decent V-shaped sound signature. They are a bright-sounding pair of earphones with underemphasised bass response, balanced mids and overemphasised highs. So, if you are a fan of bright sounding earphones, the AIWA ESTM-101 is definitely something you can consider, especially on a budget. The earphones produce detailed and crisp vocals, however, the bass response is slightly muted so you may feel a lack of drive in your music. The imaging is pretty decent though and the buds place elements of the track in a positionally accurate manner, for the most part. Additionally, the eartips provided lend to good passive isolation which increases the immersiveness. The AIWA ESTM-101 also has a good microphone. In our tests, our voice sounded clear and distinct on calls, however, the background sounds aren't suppressed too well. One can easily see why the AIWA ESTM-101 ends up bagging the Best Buy mention in this category.

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Sennheiser IE900
Price: ₹1,29,000